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AI RESULTS

Participant distribution by questionnaire and cultural group

Questionnaire	Lebanese cultural group	American cultural group	Total
A	16	15	31
B	19	10	29
Total	35	25	60

1.1. Results analysis

This is the section where the researcher analyzed the data collected from questionnaires A and B. Participants' responses to product discourse were analyzed to detect patterns in participants' attitudes (interpretations).

1.1.1. Questionnaire A: Findings of each product

Questionnaire A was used to examine how participants interpreted the verbal and visual language found in products from the Lebanese and American markets. This questionnaire was also used to elicit responses from young adults from both cultures to evaluate their understanding, feelings, and reactions (acceptance or rejection) towards product discourse and how they classified the product discourse into the categories chosen: gender related.

1.1.1.1. Domo coco powder

Figure 4.1: Domo Coco Powder - Product name and ordinary packaging

The result shows that 62.5% of Lebanese cultural responses and 66.7% of American cultural responses were none as in neutral. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "product identification/function" in both cultural groups, presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.2

Domo: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	2	12.5%	3	20%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	10	62.5%	10	66.7%
Not sure	4	25%	2	13.3%

"Nothing just a normal name for a factory serving dry ingredients (in my own mind I usually read it dough-more), so I think it's related to cake doughs and anything likewise" (LB-P13)

"I think this product and its slogan/name don't have any other alternative motive other than just marketing the product as itself" (US-P15).

1.1.1.2. Aunt Jemima

Figure 4.2: Aunt Jemima- historical brand name and Black female brand

The result shows that 43.8% of Lebanese cultural responses and 53.3% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "racial/cultural interpretations" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.3*Aunt Jemima: classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	7	43.8%	8	53.3%
Both	4	25%	5	33.3%
None	1	6.2%	1	6.7%
Not sure	4	25%	1	6.7%

"I can picture in my head that a black lady, a servant maybe, pouring syrup on a pancake plate of a white person. So yeah, it's obvious what message it conveys. Slavery, racism, and women's oppression." (LB-P15).

From prior knowledge, this was the slogan and name before their 2021 rebrand, which caused a lot of controversy with the public.

"Mammy," which is the dark-skinned woman caricature shown on the bottle, and the term "aunt", which is a racial subjugation used during the Jim Crow Era, both hold a very deep racial meaning to African American people. (US-P09)

1.1.1.3. Choco Prince

Figure 4.3: Choco Prince- "Prince" naming and male prince character

The result shows that 68.8% of Lebanese cultural responses were neutral, and 40% of American cultural responses were gender related.

The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "product identification/function" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.4*Choco Prince: classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	2	12.5%	6	40%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	1	6.7%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	11	68.8%	4	26.7%
Not sure	3	18.8%	4	26.7%

Usually, the name, image, and slogan of this product confuse me. I do not understand why they would choose such a name for a chocolate; however, I understand that we are all different and have different preferences. Personally, I cannot see a connection between the name and the product, but I guess the message is that the product is of a high quality, just like a prince. (LB-P12)

"I think because of the caricature and the word "Prince" being on the title, it seems a little bit more aimed towards a male audience, but it doesn't have any negative or positive implications to it." (US-P09)

1.1.1.4. Colgate

Figure 4.4: Colgate- conventional toothpaste branding

The result shows that 75% of Lebanese cultural responses and 86.7 % of American cultural responses were neutral. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “product identification/function” in both cultural groups, presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.5

Colgate: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	1	6.2%	0	0%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	12	75%	13	86.7%
Not sure	3	18.8%	2	13.3%

“Normal message” (LB-P13)

“I think this is a product that only neutrally promotes mouth hygiene. They don’t use a biased name or colors.” (US-P15)

1.1.1.5. Negro Steel Wool

Figure 4.5: Negro Steel Wool- racialized lexical item in the product name

The result shows that 68.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 60% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “racial/cultural interpretations” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.6

Negro Steel Wool: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	11	68.8%	9	60%
Both	2	12.5%	3	20%
None	1	6.2%	1	6.7%
Not sure	2	12.5%	2	13.3%

“The product name “NEGRO” alongside the Arabic text “أليف العبد” (Slave’s Steel Wool) and the muscular Black caricature communicates a deeply offensive and racially derogatory message rooted in anti-Black stereotypes.” (LB-P07)

“Definitely problematic. Uses slurs that would not be allowed in Western market” (US-P05)

1.1.1.6. Bic for Her

Figure 4.6: Bic for Her-explicitly gender-targeted pen branding

The result shows that 87.5% of Lebanese cultural responses and 66.7% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Gender representation” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.7

BIC for HER: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	14	87.5%	10	66.7%
Cultural/racial message	1	6.2%	0	0%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	0	0%	5	33.3%
Not sure	1	6.2%	0	0%

“It’s a pen, a pen! what it has to do with genders. Don’t like marketing at all. Looks like it built on some propaganda.” (LB-P13)

They are attempting to target women since they think women need softer, more decorated and easier to use pens. They also used pink and purple to catch their eye. I despise this since it makes women seem daintier and more incapable of using normal pens. (US-P15)

1.1.1.7. Ras Al Abed

Figure 4.7: Ras Al Abed/Tarboosh- renamed Lebanese confectioner brand

The result shows that 81.2% of Lebanese cultural responses and 73.3% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “racial/cultural interpretations” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.8

Ras Al Abed: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	1	6.7%
Cultural/racial message	13	81.2%	11	73.3%
Both	3	18.8%	2	13.3%
None	0	0%	0	0%
Not sure	0	0%	1	6.7%

Racist if translated to English. But in Arabic it’s not that racist cause I feel we were raised buying this product the whole time but never have we looked at it in a racist way. Maybe because we were kids and very gullible but also I believe that not including the image of the black person like the product before made it less obvious, insulting or racist (LB-P16)

“The name slaves head gives the message that you’re opening up/smashing their head everytime you eat one.” (US-P04)

1.1.1.8. Yorkie

Figure 4.8: Yorkie-“It’s Not for Girls!”

The result shows that 75% of Lebanese cultural responses and 93.3% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Gender representation” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.9

Yorkie: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	12	75%	14	93.3%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	2	12.5%	0	0%
None	0	0%	0	0%
Not sure	2	12.5%	1	6.7%

“The slogan “IT’S NOT FOR GIRLS!” and the “no women” symbol on the chocolate bar wrapper communicates a message that intentionally excludes women to market the product exclusively to men.” (LB-P07)

Saying it's not for girls makes it seem that it has ingredients that might affect a girl's health and that this is not a normal or safe candy bar.

Both the slogan and the image are offensive and I wouldnt eat it even if i were a boy. (US-P15)

1.1.1.9. Special K

Figure 4.9: Special K- “ Drop a Jean Size”

The result shows that 31.2% of Lebanese-cultural responses were neutral and 40% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Body/beauty” representation in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.10

Special K: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	3	18.8%	6	40%
Cultural/racial message	3	18.8%	2	13.3%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	5	31.2%	3	20%
Not sure	5	31.2%	4	26.7%

It reflects societal stereotype that a woman’s worth, attractiveness, and success are tied to being thin. By focusing specifically on a “jeans size,” it plays into toxic diet culture, implying that shrinking one's body should be a primary and urgent goal. (LB-P05)

“Tells women their bodies need to be fixed or managed. “Special” really means smaller, thinner. it targets insecurity, not health.” (US-P10)

1.1.1.10. Vileda

Figure 4.10: Vileda-cleaning-product discourse and domestic imagery

The result shows that 50 % of Lebanese cultural responses and 66.7% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.11

Vileda: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	8	50%	10	66.7%
Cultural/racial message	1	6.2%	0	0%
Both	5	31.2%	4	26.7%
None	1	6.2%	1	6.7%
Not sure	1	6.2%	0	0%

"Omg ! That's one of the reason why I consider turning myself into a feminist. Why would these Arab men consider cleaning is only a women's job?" (LB-P16)

"it communicates a message that directly links cleaning and domestic labor to a specific gender." (US-P06)

1.1.2. Questionnaire B: Product-by Product Findings

4.1.2.1 Two Girls Tuna

Figure 4.11: Two Girls Tuna- Gendered product naming

The result shows that 36.8 % of Lebanese cultural responses and 80% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product. For many, the name of the product was confusing.

Table 4.12

Two Girls Tuna: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	7	36.8%	8	80%
Cultural/racial message	1	5.3%	0	0%
Both	5	26.3%	0	0%
None	2	10.5%	1	10%
Not sure	4	21.1%	1	10%

"Some two girls that made this tuna" (LB-P29)

"Why is tuna named two girls? I dont know what is meant by this."(US-P25)

1.1.2.1. Fair & Lovely

Figure 4.12: Fair & Lovely-beauty/skin-tone wording: later Glow & Lovely

The result shows that 21.1% of Lebanese-cultural responses as racial, gender related or both equally while 50% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were "racial/cultural interpretations" and "product identification/function" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.13

Fair & Lovely: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	4	21.1%	3	30%
Cultural/racial message	4	21.1%	5	50%
Both	4	21.1%	1	10%
None	4	21.1%	1	10%
Not sure	3	15.8%	0	0%

“It communicates that lighter skin is the standard for beauty, confidence, and success, implying that darker skin tones are a flaw that needs to be corrected” (LB-P25)

“It’s showing that being fair is “lovely”. Racist against other skin colors” (US-P22)

1.1.2.2. Land O’Lakes

Figure 4.13: Land O’Lakes- historical Native American women imagery

The result shows that 36.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 60% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were “racial/cultural interpretations” and “product identification/function” in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.14

Land O’ Lakes : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	7	36.8%	6	60%
Both	5	26.3%	1	10%
None	3	15.8%	2	20%
Not sure	4	21.1%	1	10%

“Using the image of a Native American as a marketing gimmick for products they had no historical connection with—simply to project an exoticized vibe of nature and purity whitewashed the tragic and dark history of forced displacement and genocide that the indigenous population faced at the hands of colonizers, and I think this they removed the Native girl from the butter packaing. (LB-P31)

“Uses a Native American woman as a symbol of nature and wholesomeness, reducing Indigenous identity to a decorative mascot for a product she has no cultural connection to.” (US-P21)

1.1.2.3. Beesline

Figure 4.14: Beesline- beauty/skin-care discourse

The result shows that 68.4 % of Lebanese-cultural responses and 100 % of American cultural responses were none. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “product identification/function” in both cultural groups presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.15

Beesline: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	13	68.4%	10	100%
Not sure	6	31.6%	0	13.3%

1.1.2.4. Uncle Ben's

Figure 4.15: Uncle Ben's -historical brand name and black male image; later Ben's Original

The result shows that 36.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 40% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were "racial/cultural interpretations" and "product identification/function" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.16

Uncle Ben's : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	7	36.8%	4	40%
Both	3	15.8%	1	10%
None	4	21.1%	3	30%
Not sure	5	26.3%	2	20%

Historically, the imagery and name relied on southern American agricultural tropes. The portrait of an elderly Black man alongside the title "Uncle" evokes domestic servant archetypes from the 19th and early 20th centuries, as Black individuals in the American South were often addressed as "Uncle" or "Aunt" rather than formal honorifics like "Mr" (LB-P25)

"Name is reflective of Jim Crow era phrases used to degrade Black Americans" (US-P18)

1.1.2.5. Mr. Clean

Figure 4.16: Mr. Clean-male cleaning mascot and strength-coded identity

The result shows that 36.8 % of Lebanese-cultural responses were none and 80 % of American cultural responses were gender-related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.17

Mr. Clean : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	5	26.3%	8	80%
Cultural/racial message	1	5.3%	0	0%
Both	3	15.8%	1	10%
None	7	36.8%	1	10%
Not sure	3	15.8%	0	0%

This Mother's Day, Get Back To The Job That Really Matters" superimposed over a woman cleaning reinforces traditional patriarchal gender roles. It communicates a regressive message that a woman's primary, most important responsibility is domestic labor and cleaning, even on a day meant to celebrate her (LB-P25)

communicates that a woman's most important role is cleaning the house. By tying it to Mother's Day, it wraps that message in something that's supposed to feel celebratory, but really just sends mothers back to domestic labor as if that's their true purpose. (US-P21)

1.1.2.6. Old Spice

Figure 4.17: Old Spice- "Smell like a Man, Man"/ Masculine grooming discourse

The result shows that 42.1% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 80% of American cultural responses were gender-related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.18

Old Spice : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	8	42.1%	8	80%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	3	15.8%	1	10%
None	3	15.8%	1	10%
Not sure	5	26.3%	0	0%

"The slogan suggests masculinity, confidence, and strength. It is designed to appeal to male consumers by associating the product with a masculine identity and a distinctive, attractive scent" (LB-P21)

"A man is supposed to smell a certain way it's connecting imagery of strength/wildness" (US-P16)

1.1.2.7. Al Warda

Figure 4.18: Al Warda- name and image

The result shows that 42.1 % of Lebanese-cultural responses were gender related, while 50 % of American cultural responses were not sure and the other 50% were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.19

Al-Warda : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	8	42.1%	5	50%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	3	15.8%	0	0%
None	2	10.5%	0	0%
Not sure	6	31.6%	5	50%

"Reflecting women's beauty in a bad sexual image. Even the slogan is irritating." (LB-P27)

"I dont understand but I think theyre using woman to promote" (US-P24)

1.1.2.8. Dark & Lovely

Figure 4.19: Dark & Lovely - racialized/beauty-related brand wording

The result shows that 36.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses were both gender-related and racial/cultural while 40% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were "racial/cultural interpretations" and "Body/beauty interpretation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.20

Dark & Lovely: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	5	26.3%	2	20%
Cultural/racial message	2	10.5%	4	40%
Both	7	36.8%	2	20%
None	3	15.8%	0	0%
Not sure	2	10.5%	2	20%

"The product's name "Dark & Lovely" and the imagery of smooth, flowing hair communicate a message of empowering and celebrating the beauty of dark complexions by promoting deeply nourished, straightened, and healthy hair."(LB-P30)

"Is this product for hair or skin? Either way dark and lovely is like the fair and lovely product. This is promoting 1 type of beauty and excluding another." (US-P24)

1.1.2.9. Clorox

Figure 4.20: Clorox-conventional cleaning-product branding

The result shows that 84.2 % of Lebanese-cultural responses and 90 % of American cultural responses were none. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “product identification/function” in both cultural groups presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.21

Clorox: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	1	5.3%	0	0%
None	16	84.2%	9	90%
Not sure	2	10.5%	0	0%

1.1.3. Products for Researcher’s Analysis

1.1.3.1. Cablevision

Figure 4.21: Cablevision- female body used as the visual field for channel information

Cablevision objectified a female’s body as if it were one of its billboards by printing channel names directly on her bare skin. Also, the question presented under the offer, “do you want to or not?”, adds another meaning of the ad when all the linguistic features are combined. This combination also raises several questions on the exact meaning the ad is trying to convey.

1.1.3.2. Ritika Shoes

Figure 4.22:Ritika-religiously significant female names used as online product names

This example shows how a name, even if it is not physically visible on the product, can cause controversy. Ritika promoted its new line of women’s shoes with well-known Arabic names with religious significance. These names were recognized by the Lebanese consumers as religious names which led to public criticism of the company and demands the removal of the names.

1.1.3.3. NIVEA- Re-Civilize Yourself

Figure 4.23:NIVEA for Men- “ Re-Civilize Yourself”

NIVEA promoted its new grooming line by using the slogan “RE-CIVILIZE YOURSELF” with a black man holding a head with an afro hairstyle. The combination of the words themselves with the depicted head with the afro hair creates a relationship between the afro hairstyle and being uncivilized. In addition, the slogan was written in all caps; this can highlight this part and grab the consumer’s attention to the message communicated by the ad. The choice of using a black man and then presenting the picture together with the slogan suggests that to look civilized, you need to change the identity presented in the image.

1.1.3.4. H&M- Coolest Monkey in the jungle

Figure 4.24: H&M- Black child model wearing “Coolest Monkey in the jungle” hoodie

This ad shows when multimodal features in a product work together to deliver a certain message. A Black child is modeling an H&M hoodie with the phrase "The Coolest Monkey in the Jungle." The slogan by itself is playful and can be printed on clothing; however, when it is presented on a Black child it refers to the historical association between Black people and monkeys. This interaction between the lexical element and the visual identity creates a racialized message.

1.1.3.5. AXE- he Cleaner You Are, the dirtier You Get

Figure 4.25: AXE- "The Cleaner You Are, The dirtier You Get"

AXE promoted its body wash products by using lexical ambiguity. The company's slogan "The Cleaner You Are, The Dirtier You Get" uses two opposing ideas at the same time. This contradiction raises the question of how becoming cleaner makes you dirtier, and then realizes that by using the word cleaner, AXE is referring to your actual physical state, and the word dirtier implies being naughty or having sexual urges. The slogan uses a double meaning in its product discourse to construct an implied meaning.

1.1.3.6. Dr. Pepper TEN- It's Not for Women.

Figure 4.26: 4.2.2.6. Dr. Pepper TEN- It's Not for Women.

The slogan "IT'S NOT FOR WOMEN" explicitly communicates a gender-related message. Unlike other products that use blue, horses, or cars to target a certain gender, this product directly excludes women from its target audience. The company used the slogan to position the product as exclusively for men and explicitly exclude women.

1.1.3.7. Red Man

Figure 4.27: Red Man-brand name with Native American imagery; later America's Best Chew

This tobacco company combined the product's name with an image of a Native American on its packaging which can be interpreted as a racial message. This combination of the lexical and the visual element constructs a particular cultural identity. This combination can contribute to the stereotyping of an entire culture.

1.1.3.8. Mr. Muscle

Figure 4.28: Mr. Muscle- cleaning power personified through masculine strength

Unlike the cleaning products in the corpus that usually use the image of women, this product that uses "Mr. Muscle" with a masculine character to associate it with strength and toughness. This company personified the power of this product through the interaction of the lexical and visual elements presented.

1.1.3.9. Dimex

Figure 4.29: Dimex - comparatively neutral product stimulus

1.1.3.10. Pringles

Figure 4.30: Pringles- Comparatively neutral commercial branding

The last two selected products were treated as comparatively neutral because the linguistic features do not explicitly convey racial or gender messages. They target a general audience. The first one, Dimex is presented as a cleaning product with vibrant colors, and the second one, Pringles, is presented as a chips brand. These two products were selected to add an analytical comparison with other products in the market.

1.2. Discussion of the findings

This section showed that the same product can be interpreted in multiple ways. One response from the Lebanese cultural group and one response from the American cultural group for each product were used as examples of the patterns found. However, the following discussion considers all the responses from both cultural groups across both questionnaires. To support the qualitative findings, counts and percentages were used descriptively. This section follows the analytical procedure used in Chapter Three.

1.2.1. Deductive thematic analysis of participants' interpretations

The literature reviewed provided the theoretical foundation that helped analyze participants' responses and understand their interpretations. It also helped in classifying those responses into categories mentioned above. After that, it helped identify patterns within these responses, which were examined in relation to sociocultural contexts in product discourse across the two cultural groups.

An important finding is that there was a difference between identifying a product and interpreting its verbal and visual language. The responses showed this distinction clearly. Some interpretations stopped identifying the types of products, while others examined the meaning of product discourse more deeply and analyzed the products' multimodal elements and their interaction in constructing meaning. The interpretations were not only about understanding what the product is but also about communicating the multiple meanings through its discourse.

This is clearly shown in the examples of products that are associated with historical and sociocultural backgrounds such as Aunt Jemima, Land O'Lakes, and Ras Al Abed. Some participants identified these products as types of food when their interpretations remained at the level of product identification. Others were able to interpret the product discourse at multiple levels by associating it with the historical or sociocultural contexts. Some participants from the Lebanese-cultural group referred to Uncle Ben's as rice, while others from the same group interpreted the multimodal elements as racial/cultural messages, which indicates that participants from the same cultural group do not automatically interpret discourse in the same way.

Gender representation was another pattern found across participants' interpretations in products such as BIC, Vileda, Old Spice, Mr. Clean, Two Girls, Al Warda, and Special K. These interpretations varied between masculinity and domestic roles. Some products explicitly communicated the messages to participants as shown in Yorkie "It's not for Girls" and BIC "For Her" while other products implied the message, and participants relied on the interaction of multimodal elements in interpreting the meaning as shown in Mr. Clean and Old Spice. Several products from the researcher's list also demonstrated gender representations such as Cablevision, Dr. Pepper TEN, AXE, and Mr. Muscle. This shows that gender discourse can be constructed through the interaction of multimodal elements.

Another theme that was visible through the participants' interpretations was the racial/cultural representation in products like Negro Steel Wool, Ras Al Abed, and Aunt Jemima. These examples contained lexical or visual features that evoked racial associations. However, participants had different interpretations of products such as Aunt Jemima, Uncle Ben's, and Land O'Lakes as such historical references may depend on the knowledge of the historical context surrounding the discourse. Several products from the researcher's list also demonstrated race-related messages, such as Red Man and NIVEA. Therefore, discourse containing explicit verbal or visual elements might be easier to interpret than those that require contextual information.

Neutral products are considered essential components that act as an internal comparative baseline. Products such as Domo, Colgate, Clorox, and Beesline from the questionnaire were interpreted as neutral with no racial or gender-related messages by many participants. Other products that carried neutral representation were Dimex and Pringles from the researcher's list. Including neutral products in the questionnaires showed that the participants did not associate products randomly with racial/cultural or gender representation.

1.2.2. Interpretation through the tripartite model of attitude

Rosenberg and Hovland (1960) divided attitude into three separate dimensions, while Breckler (1984) provided evidence that these dimensions are distinct but related, which is important for the findings in this study. Participants who evaluated the verbal and visual language in products as negative did not necessarily reject it. The dataset showed that participants could refer to a product positively while also recognizing racial representations.

1.2.2.1. Cognitive Dimension Pattern

The cognitive dimension concerns thoughts and how participants understand the messages through product discourse. This type of understanding depends on the multimodal elements found in the product and the prior knowledge the participants possess. This explains why some participants were only able to interpret the product discourse in Aunt Jemima and Land O'Lakes as syrup and dairy. These Lebanese participants did not demonstrate prior knowledge that would allow them to associate the products with race-related messages. In addition to differences related to prior knowledge, the cognitive dimension is also related to familiarity. Constant exposure to a certain brand, name, or slogan may normalize the meaning of a certain message. For example, Ras Al Abed provides an example of this pattern. LB-P16 mentioned that this product includes a racial message in its name, but her familiarity with the product since childhood may have normalized the name over time.

Using explicit lexical features or visual elements in a product makes it cognitively easier and faster to interpret the product discourse. Examples like BIC For Her or the slogan NOT FOR GIRLS were easier to interpret by participants as carrying explicit meanings.

1.2.2.2. Affective dimension pattern

This is the second dimension, which is related to how participants felt toward the visual and verbal language used in the selected products. Some participants viewed a product carrying a racial or gender-related message as negative. Many participants cognitively associated a product with a racial or gender-related message and evaluated it as neutral or positive. Also, the neutral products showed that participants did not automatically assign racial/cultural or gender-related meaning to every item.

1.2.2.3. Behavioral dimension pattern

The questions did not explicitly ask participants about buying or rejecting the product even though the acceptance question indicated the behavioral dimension. Some of the answers showed whether participants accepted or rejected a product. One response explicitly stated that she would not eat Yorkie Chocolate even if she were a boy. Another participant described Ras Al Abed as racist but stated she would buy it anyway for its taste. This explains that participants sometimes do not reject a product just because it has negative messages, while at other times they do.

1.2.3. Cross-cultural convergence and divergence

Cross-cultural comparison is important for examining responses between the Lebanese-cultural group and the American-cultural group and identifying similarities and differences in their interpretations. As mentioned before, participants from both cultural groups showed similar recognition when the multimodal elements contained explicit racial or gender-related messages such as Ras Al Abed and Yorkie, while in other cases, participants' prior knowledge of historical and sociocultural background influenced interpretation. This study did not limit participants to certain nationalities but concentrated on their cultural background and upbringing in Lebanese or American culture. A product can be known as Lebanese or American from the visual and verbal language used; for example, a product that has a cedar tree sold in both markets will project a sense of belonging to Lebanese consumers; however, Americans might know this is a Lebanese product, but it will not project the same sense of belonging.

On the other hand, participants from the same cultural group also had differences in their responses, which indicates that sharing the same cultural context may influence participants' responses, but differences can still appear in the same cultural group. These differences might be related to familiarity and prior knowledge. This is not limited to participants from the same culture but also to different cultures, so differences found between the Lebanese-cultural group and the American-cultural group should not be understood as fixed differences between the two cultures but as differences that might be related to familiarity, association, and prior knowledge all together.

Greater similarities appeared when the visual or verbal language in products had explicit elements that guided participants' interpretations which indicate that meaning is constructed through the interaction between the multimodal elements and participants' social knowledge and in return shapes their interpretations. This explains why several products in this study showed similar patterns of interpretations across cultures, while other products received different interpretations within the same cultural groups.

4.2.6 Rebranding and the evolution of product discourse

Language is not fixed; it changes over time. As long as societies are changing, language may change. Rebranding is an example of language change in product discourse that reflects the change in social norms, beliefs, and public knowledge. This process of changing names, slogans, or even images was seen in several products used in this study. Product discourse is prone to change in response to consumers' attitudes toward changes in product discourse. Rebranding also supports the idea that a symbol that was accepted in a certain period might not be accepted later in the same society and may be interpreted as stereotypical, racist, sexist or just inappropriate. Aunt Jemima was rebranded and the company removed the image of the Black lady from their syrup bottles to become Pearl Milling Company in 2021. PepsiCo mentioned that the Aunt Jemima brand carried racial stereotyping messages before the company rebranded (PepsiCo, 2021). Fair and Lovely removed any word that is associated with white, light, or fair and became Glow & Lovely and changed the picture of the brown lady with half face brown and the other half white (Unilever, 2020). Uncle Ben's was also rebranded to Ben's Original and removed the image of the Black man (Mars Food, 2020). This kind of rebranding was not only related to changing the name or the image of a product but rather rebuilding new identities and values.

Other cases involved companies that rebranded their products and apologized for delivering any racial or gender-related issues. NIVEA apologized after launching the ad with the Black man holding a head with an afro hairstyle and removed the commercial altogether, which was the case with H&M that also removed the ad instead of rebranding (Tumposky, 2011; John, 2018). Gandour also renamed Ras Al Abed to Tarboosh (Abou Dib, 2020). The new name carries a more Lebanese identity than Ras Al Abed. Ritika removed any controversial images or ads related to shoes with names associated with religious figures on social media (L'Orient Today Staff, 2025). These examples show that companies might change the name, image, slogan, or sometimes remove the whole advertisement.

Companies may rebrand in response to consumers' criticism of product discourse. This study does not claim that rebranding happens only because of criticism, but the examples show rebranding happens in parallel to changes in social norms and values over time.

1.3. Testing hypotheses

This section of Chapter Four tests the two hypotheses in this thesis using questionnaire classifications, responses to open-ended questions, and patterns across responses.

1.3.1. Testing hypothesis one

H₁: Meaning constructed through the linguistic features within product multimodal elements influences the interpretation of young adults and shapes their response to product discourse, leading to rebranding in most cases.

The interaction between the multimodal elements in product discourse and the rebranding cases both support the first hypothesis. Responses to product discourse that had explicit visual and verbal elements, such as in BIC for Her and Negro Steel Wool, were similar across the two cultural groups. Most participants from both cultures agreed that BIC for Her included gender-related messages, and most participants from both cultures classified Negro Steel Wool as racial/cultural-related. The Yorkie response from US-P15 contains the three dimensions of the Tripartite Model of Attitude where the participants recognized the product and its slogan, effectively interpreted the message as offensive, and showed her rejection of buying the product. This indicates that Hypothesis 1 is supported by the evidence mentioned through the importance of multimodal elements' function in product discourse.

1.3.2. Testing hypothesis two

H₂: The Lebanese sociocultural values, beliefs, and consumers' interpretations are different from those of the United States because of the distinct linguistic choices used in the verbal and visual language of products.

The patterns found across responses supported the hypothesis, but the data showed that divergence also happened in the same cultural group, so the Lebanese-cultural group and the American cultural group cannot be treated as opposites because participants interpreted product discourse in some products the same way while in other products the interpretations varied. Examples like Choco Prince and Mr. Clean were classified as neutral by most participants from the Lebanese Cultural group while they were classified as gender related by most participants from the American Cultural Group. This shows that there are differences in the interpretation of the same product discourse. Another difference can be spotted in the Dark and Lovely interpretations of LB-P30 and US-P18. The Lebanese participant interpreted it as celebrating Black beauty, while the American participant interpreted the message as not accepting natural Black identity. Several Lebanese participants interpreted the message of a Black lady with smooth hair as a message of empowerment while many American participants interpreted it as meaning that the Black lady's natural hair needs to be relaxed to follow Eurocentric standards. This divergence is consistent with sociocultural knowledge. Another example that shows how different sociocultural backgrounds and levels of familiarity may influence interpretations of Ras Al Abed. Lebanese consumers said that familiarity led to normalizing the name, while American participants found the translated name racist as shown in LB-P16 and US-PO9's responses.

1.4. Answering research questions

1.4.1. Answering research question one

1. How do the products' multimodal elements (names, slogans, and images) construct meanings and shape young adult consumers' interpretation across different cultural contexts?

This question is answered through the responses from both cultural groups to products with explicit visual and verbal elements. For example, the slogan "It's not for Girls" with the image of a girl in the prohibition circle or using the word "Negro" in Negro Steel Wool and combining it with a picture of a Black Muscular figure associated with greater convergent responses from both groups. Also, neutral products included visual and verbal elements such as relevant colors, images, and neutral names that communicated the function of the products rather than conveying racial/cultural or gender-related messages. The interaction between the multimodal elements shaped the interpretations across cultures.

1.4.2. Answering research question two

2. How can the verbal and visual language of products affect the three dimensions of attitude of young adult consumers?

Participants answered the open-ended questions that were organized in the questionnaire to match the pattern of the Tripartite Model of Attitude. Participants wrote what message they understood, how they felt towards the language in the provided products, and showed behavior towards product discourse in the acceptability question. Several responses showed that these three dimensions are distinct but related. In this study, the cognitive and affective dimensions were tested more than the behavioral dimension, but many participants included the way they would react in their responses.

1.4.3. Answering research question three

3. What are the similarities and differences in consumers' attitudes toward product discourse in both countries?

This question was answered in detail in the Cross-Cultural Convergence and Divergence section. The study showed similarities and differences in responses from both cultural groups. Similarities were more noticeable when the product included explicit verbal and visual language that conveyed recognizable meanings. However, differences appeared to depend on participants prior knowledge, sociocultural background, and shared values, but these differences existed within the same cultural group. This indicates that shared values, social norms, and cultural background may influence interpretation, but interpretation does not depend solely on these factors.

1.4.4. Answering question four

4. How can sociocultural norms and historical change influence the interpretation of products names, slogans, and images?

As mentioned before, sociocultural norms and historical changes may influence interpretation of product discourse by evaluating whether a name is acceptable or not, or an image is appropriate or not. Participants interpreting Uncle Ben's from the Lebanese cultural group did not recognize the historical context in their interpretations. Other responses of Ras Al Abed and Aunt Jemima also showed that sharing social norms influences interpretations.

1.4.5. Answering question five

5. Do consumers' attitudes affect the product discourse leading to rebranding?

Rebranding of some selected products was not due to participants' interpretations; however, their responses showing recognition, evaluation, and reactions towards the language used in products show patterns that might appear in consumers' responses to product discourse in contexts where rebranding occurred. Consumers' attitudes might be one of the reasons that led to rebranding, but this study cannot prove that consumers' attitudes are the cause of rebranding.

1.5. Chapter summary

Findings from Questionnaire A, Questionnaire B, and the 10 products analyzed by the researcher were discussed in this chapter. The findings indicated that meaning may be constructed through verbal or visual elements, but the interaction between the multimodal elements in a product creates additional meanings. The findings also indicated that shared knowledge, values, and social norms might influence interpretations, but they are not the only factors that shape them. Including neutral products was very important to validate the responses, and it showed that participants did not randomly choose or answer questions.

Chapter 2. Conclusion

2.1. Conclusion

This study examined how young adult participants' attitudes are influenced by product discourse through the Tripartite Model of attitude. It did not test attitude towards the product itself, but towards the verbal and visual language in products found in Lebanese and American markets. It also tested if these interpretations are affected by sociocultural factors, shared knowledge, and time.

The findings in this study showed that some participants interpreted product discourse at multiple levels. Some only interpreted the literal meaning while others dived deeper into the hidden meanings conveyed through the multimodal elements in products. Products that explicitly used verbal and visual language that have racial and gender-related messages were interpreted as such across cultures despite their social backgrounds. Other products that implied meaning through the visual and verbal language needed participants' shared knowledge, sociocultural, and historical background to be able to interpret the message.

This study also showed that meaning is not constructed through the name of products but rather through the interaction between the verbal and visual language. A name might mean one thing, but when it is combined with a slogan or an image, it might mean something different. Also, the use of the Tripartite Model of Attitude organized responses into cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions. This helped to understand participants' responses: first, they understood the language used in products, then they evaluated it by expressing their feelings and indicating whether the product is negative or positive and lastly by acting towards it by accepting or rejecting it.

After that, cross-cultural comparison examined the similarities and differences between the two cultural groups which showed that similarities are found not only between participants from the same group but also between the two cultural groups. Differences are also found not only between the two cultural groups but also within the same cultural group. Findings also showed that familiarity plays a big role in shaping interpretations by normalizing racial or gender-related messages. CDA helped analyze embedded racial- or gender related messages and how meaning is constructed through the multimodal elements. Finally, rebranding showed that product discourse like language is not fixed and changes with social change and therefore is a type of language evolution.

This study is similar to several studies mentioned in Chapter Two. One finding was that gender-related or racial/cultural messages can be communicated to consumers explicitly through the use of names, images, and slogans such as BIC for Her and Yorkie. This is like the study done by Wang (2025) and Zhang (2025), who also examined gender-related advertisements. Another finding in this study was that the verbal language and visual language in products interact to construct meaning and communicate certain messages to consumers. Kayani, Mangrio, and Anwar (2022), Alifah and Hidayat (2024), Attah, Ugwu, and Sa'ad (2025), and Babayeva (2025) also had similar findings. They all showed that ads could construct meaning and communicate messages to consumers using specific linguistic and visual elements. One significant finding was that participants interpreted the same product differently in several cases. This was due to differences in the participants' familiarity with the product and their prior knowledge. Other studies by Petrea, Mihalache, and Costuleanu (2025) showed that commercials are connected to both cultural and intercultural communication, while Hazaea and Qassem (2025) showed that branding discourse affects sociocultural identity. The last finding in this study is related to rebranding. This study showed that like language, product names, images, or slogans can change over time, which was also examined in the studies done by Sangroya et al. (2026) and Ashiq and Carnie (2025). This study concentrated on examining these areas together by evaluating young adult participants' responses from two cultural backgrounds toward the verbal and visual language used in some products sold in the Lebanese and American markets.

2.2. Implications and recommendations

This study is important linguistically because it shows the usefulness of analyzing product discourse through the Tripartite Model of Attitude, multimodal analysis, and cross-cultural analysis to examine how language in products influences interpretations and how consumers' attitudes are shaped towards such products. It also shows that meaning is constructed through social context. An image alone cannot construct meaning on its own; another verbal or visual language must interact to construct meaning. The study also shows that familiarity along with shared knowledge, sociocultural and historical backgrounds influence the understanding, evaluation, and reaction towards product discourse.

This study is important because it shows that companies consider the interaction between the verbal and nonverbal elements in a product. It is important to understand how one element might mean one thing in one culture and mean something else in another, especially if these companies are creating products to be sold in different cultures to avoid misunderstanding of product discourse as sexist or racist. Another indication that makes this study important is that it shows that product discourse like language is prone to change whenever external factors influence rebranding, which is a form of language evolution.

Future researchers might consider including older generations to examine how they would recognize, evaluate, and react towards the same products and examine whether familiarity differs from one generation to another. They can also include direct questions to examine the behavioral dimension more directly, as the affective and cognitive dimensions were more thoroughly examined in this study. Future researchers could also compare interpretations of names before and after rebranding and examine any changes in consumers' attitudes over time.

2.3. Limitations of the study

The first limitation of this study was the age group, which was young adults 18-30 years old so they cannot represent the whole Lebanese or American culture, and this study cannot assume that this is how the older generation would interpret the language in the selected products. Young adults were purposely chosen so the findings apply to this selected group. The second limitation was that this study did not examine every product in the Lebanese and American markets, but only focused on the thirty selected products, so other products might be interpreted differently by consumers. The third limitation was organizing the responses from Lebanese and American cultural groups. Questionnaire A and Questionnaire B were sent to different participants from both groups, which was time consuming to organize the data. Sending two identical questionnaires and sending one as Questionnaire A and Questionnaire A1 to the participants from the Lebanese cultural group and the American cultural group respectively, and the same procedure could have been followed for Questionnaire B, could have made the organization easier and faster. This way, responses in Questionnaire A are purely from the Lebanese cultural group and responses in Questionnaire A1 would only be from the American cultural group. The last limitation was that the study only relied on questionnaire responses from the questionnaires, and adding interviews could have given the participants the opportunity to express how they might react towards product discourse. This explains how they would react but would not show whether they actually buy or reject the product.

2.4. Chapter summary

This study showed that product discourse is not used to sell products faster but can also shape consumers' interpretation and carry social meanings. It also indicated that an image alone will not construct meaning but the interaction between the verbal and visual language can help construct meaning. Another important finding is that interpretations depend on the interaction of social norms, shared knowledge, and sociocultural and historical background with familiarity. Product discourse evolves as long as society evolves.

PLAGIARISM RESULTS

Participant distribution by questionnaire and cultural group

Questionnaire	Lebanese cultural group	American cultural group	Total
A	16	15	31
B	19	10	29
Total	35	25	60

1.1. Results analysis

This is the section where the researcher analyzed the data collected from questionnaires A and B. Participants' responses to product discourse were analyzed to detect patterns in participants' attitudes (interpretations).

1.1.1. Questionnaire A: Findings of each product

Questionnaire A was used to examine how participants interpreted the verbal and visual language found in products from the Lebanese and American markets. This questionnaire was also used to elicit responses from young adults from both cultures to evaluate their understanding, feelings, and reactions (acceptance or rejection) towards product discourse and how they classified the product discourse into the categories chosen: gender related.

1.1.1.1. Domo coco powder

Figure 4.1: Domo Coco Powder - Product name and ordinary packaging

The result shows that 62.5% of Lebanese cultural responses and 66.7% of American cultural responses were none as in neutral. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "product identification/function" in both cultural groups, presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.2

Domo: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	2	12.5%	3	20%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	10	62.5%	10	66.7%
Not sure	4	25%	2	13.3%

"Nothing just a normal name for a factory serving dry ingredients (in my own mind I usually read it dough-more), so I think it's related to cake doughs and anything likewise" (LB-P13)

"I think this product and its slogan/name don't have any other alternative motive other than just marketing the product as itself" (US-P15).

1.1.1.2. Aunt Jemima

Figure 4.2: Aunt Jemima- historical brand name and Black female brand

The result shows that 43.8% of Lebanese cultural responses and 53.3% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "racial/cultural interpretations" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.3*Aunt Jemima: classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	7	43.8%	8	53.3%
Both	4	25%	5	33.3%
None	1	6.2%	1	6.7%
Not sure	4	25%	1	6.7%

"I can picture in my head that a black lady, a servant maybe, pouring syrup on a pancake plate of a white person. So yeah, it's obvious what message it conveys. Slavery, racism, and women's oppression." (LB-P15).

From prior knowledge, this was the slogan and name before their 2021 rebrand, which caused a lot of controversy with the public.

"Mammy," which is the dark-skinned woman caricature shown on the bottle, and the term "aunt", which is a racial subjugation used during the Jim Crow Era, both hold a very deep racial meaning to African American people. (US-P09)

1.1.1.3. Choco Prince

Figure 4.3: Choco Prince- "Prince" naming and male prince character

The result shows that 68.8% of Lebanese cultural responses were neutral, and 40% of American cultural responses were gender related.

The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "product identification/function" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.4*Choco Prince: classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	2	12.5%	6	40%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	1	6.7%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	11	68.8%	4	26.7%
Not sure	3	18.8%	4	26.7%

Usually, the name, image, and slogan of this product confuse me. I do not understand why they would choose such a name for a chocolate; however, I understand that we are all different and have different preferences. Personally, I cannot see a connection between the name and the product, but I guess the message is that the product is of a high quality, just like a prince. (LB-P12)

"I think because of the caricature and the word "Prince" being on the title, it seems a little bit more aimed towards a male audience, but it doesn't have any negative or positive implications to it." (US-P09)

1.1.1.4. Colgate

Figure 4.4: Colgate- conventional toothpaste branding

The result shows that 75% of Lebanese cultural responses and 86.7 % of American cultural responses were neutral. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “product identification/function” in both cultural groups, presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.5

Colgate: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	1	6.2%	0	0%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	12	75%	13	86.7%
Not sure	3	18.8%	2	13.3%

“Normal message” (LB-P13)

“I think this is a product that only neutrally promotes mouth hygiene. They don’t use a biased name or colors.” (US-P15)

1.1.1.5. Negro Steel Wool

Figure 4.5: Negro Steel Wool- racialized lexical item in the product name

The result shows that 68.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 60% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “racial/cultural interpretations” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.6

Negro Steel Wool: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	11	68.8%	9	60%
Both	2	12.5%	3	20%
None	1	6.2%	1	6.7%
Not sure	2	12.5%	2	13.3%

“The product name "NEGRO" alongside the Arabic text "ليف العبد" (Slave's Steel Wool) and the muscular Black caricature communicates a deeply offensive and racially derogatory message rooted in anti-Black stereotypes.” (LB-P07)

“Definitely problematic. Uses slurs that would not be allowed in Western market” (US-P05)

1.1.1.6. Bic for Her

Figure 4.6: Bic for Her-explicitly gender-targeted pen branding

The result shows that 87.5% of Lebanese cultural responses and 66.7% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Gender representation” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.7

BIC for HER: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	14	87.5%	10	66.7%
Cultural/racial message	1	6.2%	0	0%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	0	0%	5	33.3%
Not sure	1	6.2%	0	0%

“It's a pen, a pen! what it has to do with genders. Don't like marketing at all. Looks like it built on some propaganda.” (LB-P13)

They are attempting to target women since they think women need softer, more decorated and easier to use pens. They also used pink and purple to catch their eye. I despise this since it makes women seem daintier and more incapable of using normal pens. (US-P15)

1.1.1.7. Ras Al Abed

Figure 4.7: Ras Al Abed/Tarboosh- renamed Lebanese confectioner brand

The result shows that 81.2% of Lebanese cultural responses and 73.3% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “racial/cultural interpretations” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.8

Ras Al Abed: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	1	6.7%
Cultural/racial message	13	81.2%	11	73.3%
Both	3	18.8%	2	13.3%
None	0	0%	0	0%
Not sure	0	0%	1	6.7%

Racist if translated to English. But in Arabic it's not that racist cause I feel we were raised buying this product the whole time but never have we looked at it in a racist way. Maybe because we were kids and very gullible but also I believe that not including the image of the black person like the product before made it less obvious, insulting or racist (LB-P16)

“The name slaves head gives the message that you're opening up/smashing their head everytime you eat one.” (US-P04)

1.1.1.8. Yorkie

Figure 4.8: Yorkie- “It's Not for Girls!”

The result shows that 75% of Lebanese cultural responses and 93.3% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Gender representation” in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.9

Yorkie: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	12	75%	14	93.3%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	2	12.5%	0	0%
None	0	0%	0	0%
Not sure	2	12.5%	1	6.7%

“The slogan "IT'S NOT FOR GIRLS!" and the "no women" symbol on the chocolate bar wrapper communicates a message that intentionally excludes women to market the product exclusively to men.” (LB-P07)

Saying it's not for girls makes it seem that it has ingredients that might affect a girl's health and that this is not a normal or safe candy bar.

Both the slogan and the image are offensive and I wouldnt eat it even if i were a boy. (US-P15)

1.1.1.9. Special K

Figure 4.9: Special K- “ Drop a Jean Size”

The result shows that 31.2% of Lebanese-cultural responses were neutral and 40% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Body/beauty” representation in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.10

Special K: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	3	18.8%	6	40%
Cultural/racial message	3	18.8%	2	13.3%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	5	31.2%	3	20%
Not sure	5	31.2%	4	26.7%

It reflects societal stereotype that a woman’s worth, attractiveness, and success are tied to being thin. By focusing specifically on a "jeans size," it plays into toxic diet culture, implying that shrinking one's body should be a primary and urgent goal. (LB-P05)

“Tells women their bodies need to be fixed or managed. "Special" really means smaller, thinner. it targets insecurity, not health.” (US-P10)

1.1.1.10. Vileda

Figure 4.10: Vileda-cleaning-product discourse and domestic imagery

The result shows that 50 % of Lebanese cultural responses and 66.7% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.11

Vileda: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	8	50%	10	66.7%
Cultural/racial message	1	6.2%	0	0%
Both	5	31.2%	4	26.7%
None	1	6.2%	1	6.7%
Not sure	1	6.2%	0	0%

"Omg ! That's one of the reason why I consider turning myself into a feminist. Why would these Arab men consider cleaning is only a women's job?" (LB-P16)

"it communicates a message that directly links cleaning and domestic labor to a specific gender." (US-P06)

1.1.2. Questionnaire B: Product-by Product Findings

4.1.2.1 Two Girls Tuna

Figure 4.11: Two Girls Tuna- Gendered product naming

The result shows that 36.8 % of Lebanese cultural responses and 80% of American cultural responses were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups, representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product. For many, the name of the product was confusing.

Table 4.12

Two Girls Tuna: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	7	36.8%	8	80%
Cultural/racial message	1	5.3%	0	0%
Both	5	26.3%	0	0%
None	2	10.5%	1	10%
Not sure	4	21.1%	1	10%

"Some two girls that made this tuna" (LB-P29)

"Why is tuna named two girls? I dont know what is meant by this."(US-P25)

1.1.2.1. Fair & Lovely

Figure 4.12: Fair & Lovely-beauty/skin-tone wording: later Glow & Lovely

The result shows that 21.1% of Lebanese-cultural responses as racial, gender related or both equally while 50% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were “racial/cultural interpretations” and “product identification/function” in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.13

Fair & Lovely: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	4	21.1%	3	30%
Cultural/racial message	4	21.1%	5	50%
Both	4	21.1%	1	10%
None	4	21.1%	1	10%
Not sure	3	15.8%	0	0%

“It communicates that lighter skin is the standard for beauty, confidence, and success, implying that darker skin tones are a flaw that needs to be corrected” (LB-P25)

“It’s showing that being fair is “lovely”. Racist against other skin colors” (US-P22)

1.1.2.2. Land O’Lakes

Figure 4.13: Land O’Lakes- historical Native American women imagery

The result shows that 36.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 60% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were “racial/cultural interpretations” and “product identification/function” in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.14

Land O’ Lakes : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	7	36.8%	6	60%
Both	5	26.3%	1	10%
None	3	15.8%	2	20%
Not sure	4	21.1%	1	10%

“Using the image of a Native American as a marketing gimmick for products they had no historical connection with—simply to project an exoticized vibe of nature and purity whitewashed the tragic and dark history of forced displacement and genocide that the indigenous population faced at the hands of colonizers, and I think this they removed the Native girl from the butter packaging. (LB-P31)

“Uses a Native American woman as a symbol of nature and wholesomeness, reducing Indigenous identity to a decorative mascot for a product she has no cultural connection to.” (US-P21)

1.1.2.3. Beesline

Figure 4.14: Beesline- beauty/skin-care discourse

The result shows that 68.4 % of Lebanese-cultural responses and 100 % of American cultural responses were none. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “product identification/function” in both cultural groups presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.15

Beesline: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	0	0%	0	0%
None	13	68.4%	10	100%
Not sure	6	31.6%	0	13.3%

1.1.2.4. Uncle Ben's

Figure 4.15: Uncle Ben's -historical brand name and black male image; later Ben's Original

The result shows that 36.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 40% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were “racial/cultural interpretations” and “product identification/function” in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.16

Uncle Ben's : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	7	36.8%	4	40%
Both	3	15.8%	1	10%
None	4	21.1%	3	30%
Not sure	5	26.3%	2	20%

Historically, the imagery and name relied on southern American agricultural tropes. The portrait of an elderly Black man alongside the title "Uncle" evokes domestic servant archetypes from the 19th and early 20th centuries, as Black individuals in the American South were often addressed as "Uncle" or "Aunt" rather than formal honorifics like "Mr" (LB-P25)

“Name is reflective of Jim Crow era phrases used to degrade Black Americans” (US-P18)

1.1.2.5. Mr. Clean

Figure 4.16: Mr. Clean-male cleaning mascot and strength-coded identity

The result shows that 36.8 % of Lebanese-cultural responses were none and 80 % of American cultural responses were gender-related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “Gender representation” in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.17

Mr. Clean : classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	5	26.3%	8	80%
Cultural/racial message	1	5.3%	0	0%
Both	3	15.8%	1	10%
None	7	36.8%	1	10%
Not sure	3	15.8%	0	0%

This Mother's Day, Get Back To The Job That Really Matters" superimposed over a woman cleaning reinforces traditional patriarchal gender roles. It communicates a regressive message that a woman's primary, most important responsibility is domestic labor and cleaning, even on a day meant to celebrate her (LB-P25)

communicates that a woman's most important role is cleaning the house. By tying it to Mother's Day, it wraps that message in something that's supposed to feel celebratory, but really just sends mothers back to domestic labor as if that's their true purpose. (US-P21)

1.1.2.6. Old Spice

Figure 4.17: Old Spice- "Smell like a Man, Man"/ Masculine grooming discourse

The result shows that 42.1% of Lebanese-cultural responses and 80% of American cultural responses were gender-related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.18*Old Spice : classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	8	42.1%	8	80%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	3	15.8%	1	10%
None	3	15.8%	1	10%
Not sure	5	26.3%	0	0%

"The slogan suggests masculinity, confidence, and strength. It is designed to appeal to male consumers by associating the product with a masculine identity and a distinctive, attractive scent" (LB-P21)

"A man is supposed to smell a certain way it's connecting imagery of strength/wildness" (US-P16)

1.1.2.7. Al Warda

Figure 4.18: Al Warda- name and image

The result shows that 42.1 % of Lebanese-cultural responses were gender related, while 50 % of American cultural responses were not sure and the other 50% were gender related. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was "Gender representation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.19*Al-Warda : classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	8	42.1%	5	50%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	3	15.8%	0	0%
None	2	10.5%	0	0%
Not sure	6	31.6%	5	50%

"Reflecting women's beauty in a bad sexual image. Even the slogan is irritating." (LB-P27)

"I dont understand but I think theyre using woman to promote" (US-P24)

1.1.2.8. Dark & Lovely

Figure 4.19: Dark & Lovely - racialized/beauty-related brand wording

The result shows that 36.8% of Lebanese-cultural responses were both gender-related and racial/cultural while 40% of American cultural responses were racial/cultural. The themes that dominated this open-ended question were "racial/cultural interpretations" and "Body/beauty interpretation" in both cultural groups representing a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.20*Dark & Lovely: classification by cultural group*

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	5	26.3%	2	20%
Cultural/racial message	2	10.5%	4	40%
Both	7	36.8%	2	20%
None	3	15.8%	0	0%
Not sure	2	10.5%	2	20%

"The product's name "Dark & Lovely" and the imagery of smooth, flowing hair communicate a message of empowering and celebrating the beauty of dark complexions by promoting deeply nourished, straightened, and healthy hair."(LB-P30)

"Is this product for hair or skin? Either way dark and lovely is like the fair and lovely product. This is promoting 1 type of beauty and excluding another." (US-P24)

1.1.2.9. Clorox

Figure 4.20: Clorox-conventional cleaning-product branding

The result shows that 84.2 % of Lebanese-cultural responses and 90 % of American cultural responses were none. The theme that dominated this open-ended question was “product identification/function” in both cultural groups presenting a common pattern, while participants used their own words to express their interpretation of the intended message or meaning behind this product.

Table 4.21

Clorox: classification by cultural group

Classification	LB n	LB%	US n	US %
Gender-related message	0	0%	0	0%
Cultural/racial message	0	0%	0	0%
Both	1	5.3%	0	0%
None	16	84.2%	9	90%
Not sure	2	10.5%	0	0%

1.1.3. Products for Researcher’s Analysis

1.1.3.1. Cablevision

Figure 4.21: Cablevision- female body used as the visual field for channel information

Cablevision objectified a female’s body as if it were one of its billboards by printing channel names directly on her bare skin. Also, the question presented under the offer, “do you want to or not?”, adds another meaning of the ad when all the linguistic features are combined. This combination also raises several questions on the exact meaning the ad is trying to convey.

1.1.3.2. Ritika Shoes

Figure 4.22:Ritika-religiously significant female names used as online product names

This example shows how a name, even if it is not physically visible on the product, can cause controversy. Ritika promoted its new line of women’s shoes with well-known Arabic names with religious significance. These names were recognized by the Lebanese consumers as religious names which led to public criticism of the company and demands the removal of the names.

1.1.3.3. NIVEA- Re-Civilize Yourself

Figure 4.23:NIVEA for Men- “ Re-Civilize Yourself”

NIVEA promoted its new grooming line by using the slogan “RE-CIVILIZE YOURSELF” with a black man holding a head with an afro hairstyle. The combination of the words themselves with the depicted head with the afro hair creates a relationship between the afro hairstyle and being uncivilized. In addition, the slogan was written in all caps; this can highlight this part and grab the consumer’s attention to the message communicated by the ad. The choice of using a black man and then presenting the picture together with the slogan suggests that to look civilized, you need to change the identity presented in the image.

1.1.3.4. H&M- Coolest Monkey in the jungle

Figure 4.24: H&M- Black child model wearing “Coolest Monkey in the jungle” hoodie

This ad shows when multimodal features in a product work together to deliver a certain message. A Black child is modeling an H&M hoodie with the phrase “The Coolest Monkey in the Jungle.” The slogan by itself is playful and can be printed on clothing; however, when it is presented on a Black child it refers to the historical association between Black people and monkeys. This interaction between the lexical element and the visual identity creates a racialized message.

1.1.3.5. AXE- he Cleaner You Are, the dirtier You Get

Figure 4.25: AXE- “The Cleaner You Are, The dirtier You Get”

AXE promoted its body wash products by using lexical ambiguity. The company’s slogan “The Cleaner You Are, The Dirtier You Get” uses two opposing ideas at the same time. This contradiction raises the question of how becoming cleaner makes you dirtier, and then realizes that by using the word cleaner, AXE is referring to your actual physical state, and the word dirtier implies being naughty or having sexual urges. The slogan uses a double meaning in its product discourse to construct an implied meaning.

1.1.3.6. Dr. Pepper TEN- It’s Not for Women.

Figure 4.26: 4.2.2.6. Dr. Pepper TEN- It’s Not for Women.

The slogan “IT’S NOT FOR WOMEN” explicitly communicates a gender-related message. Unlike other products that use blue, horses, or cars to target a certain gender, this product directly excludes women from its target audience. The company used the slogan to position the product as exclusively for men and explicitly exclude women.

1.1.3.7. Red Man

Figure 4.27: Red Man-brand name with Native American imagery; later America’s Best Chew

This tobacco company combined the product’s name with an image of a Native American on its packaging which can be interpreted as a racial message. This combination of the lexical and the visual element constructs a particular cultural identity. This combination can contribute to the stereotyping of an entire culture.

1.1.3.8. Mr. Muscle

Figure 4.28: Mr. Muscle- cleaning power personified through masculine strength

Unlike the cleaning products in the corpus that usually use the image of women, this product that uses “Mr. Muscle” with a masculine character to associate it with strength and toughness. This company personified the power of this product through the interaction of the lexical and visual elements presented.

1.1.3.9. Dimex

Figure 4.29: Dimex - comparatively neutral product stimulus

1.1.3.10. Pringles

Figure 4.30: Pringles- Comparatively neutral commercial branding

The last two selected products were treated as comparatively neutral because the linguistic features do not explicitly convey racial or gender messages. They target a general audience. The first one, Dimex is presented as a cleaning product with vibrant colors, and the second one, Pringles, is presented as a chips brand. These two products were selected to add an analytical comparison with other products in the market.

1.2. Discussion of the findings

This section showed that the same product can be interpreted in multiple ways. One response from the Lebanese cultural group and one response from the American cultural group for each product were used as examples of the patterns found. However, the following discussion considers all the responses from both cultural groups across both questionnaires. To support the qualitative findings, counts and percentages were used descriptively. This section follows the analytical procedure used in Chapter Three.

1.2.1. Deductive thematic analysis of participants' interpretations

The literature reviewed provided the theoretical foundation that helped analyze participants' responses and understand their interpretations. It also helped in classifying those responses into categories mentioned above. After that, it helped identify patterns within these responses, which were examined in relation to sociocultural contexts in product discourse across the two cultural groups.

An important finding is that there was a difference between identifying a product and interpreting its verbal and visual language. The responses showed this distinction clearly. Some interpretations stopped identifying the types of products, while others examined the meaning of product discourse more deeply and analyzed the products' multimodal elements and their interaction in constructing meaning. The interpretations were not only about understanding what the product is but also about communicating the multiple meanings through its discourse.

This is clearly shown in the examples of products that are associated with historical and sociocultural backgrounds such as Aunt Jemima, Land O'Lakes, and Ras Al Abed. Some participants identified these products as types of food when their interpretations remained at the level of product identification. Others were able to interpret the product discourse at multiple levels by associating it with the historical or sociocultural contexts. Some participants from the Lebanese-cultural group referred to Uncle Ben's as rice, while others from the same group interpreted the multimodal elements as racial/cultural messages, which indicates that participants from the same cultural group do not automatically interpret discourse in the same way.

Gender representation was another pattern found across participants' interpretations in products such as BIC, Vileda, Old Spice, Mr. Clean, Two Girls, Al Warda, and Special K. These interpretations varied between masculinity and domestic roles. Some products explicitly communicated the messages to participants as shown in Yorkie "It's not for Girls" and BIC "For Her" while other products implied the message, and participants relied on the interaction of multimodal elements in interpreting the meaning as shown in Mr. Clean and Old Spice. Several products from the researcher's list also demonstrated gender representations such as Cablevision, Dr. Pepper TEN, AXE, and Mr. Muscle. This shows that gender discourse can be constructed through the interaction of multimodal elements.

Another theme that was visible through the participants' interpretations was the racial/cultural representation in products like Negro Steel Wool, Ras Al Abed, and Aunt Jemima. These examples contained lexical or visual features that evoked racial associations. However, participants had different interpretations of products such as Aunt Jemima, Uncle Ben's, and Land O'Lakes as such historical references may depend on the knowledge of the historical context surrounding the discourse. Several products from the researcher's list also demonstrated race-related messages, such as Red Man and NIVEA. Therefore, discourse containing explicit verbal or visual elements might be easier to interpret than those that require contextual information.

Neutral products are considered essential components that act as an internal comparative baseline. Products such as Domo, Colgate, Clorox, and Beesline from the questionnaire were interpreted as neutral with no racial or gender-related messages by many participants. Other products that carried neutral representation were Dimex and Pringles from the researcher's list. Including neutral products in the questionnaires showed that the participants did not associate products randomly with racial/cultural or gender representation.

1.2.2. Interpretation through the tripartite model of attitude

Rosenberg and Hovland (1960) divided attitude into three separate dimensions, while Breckler (1984) provided evidence that these dimensions are distinct but related, which is important for the findings in this study. Participants who evaluated the verbal and visual language in products as negative did not necessarily reject it. The dataset showed that participants could refer to a product positively while also recognizing racial representations.

1.2.2.1. Cognitive Dimension Pattern

The cognitive dimension concerns thoughts and how participants understand the messages through product discourse. This type of understanding depends on the multimodal elements found in the product and the prior knowledge the participants possess. This explains why some participants were only able to interpret the product discourse in Aunt Jemima and Land O'Lakes as syrup and dairy. These Lebanese participants did not demonstrate prior knowledge that would allow them to associate the products with race-related messages. In addition to differences related to prior knowledge, the cognitive dimension is also related to familiarity. Constant exposure to a certain brand, name, or slogan may normalize the meaning of a certain message. For example, Ras Al Abed provides an example of this pattern. LB-P16 mentioned that this product includes a racial message in its name, but her familiarity with the product since childhood may have normalized the name over time.

Using explicit lexical features or visual elements in a product makes it cognitively easier and faster to interpret the product discourse.

Examples like BIC For Her or the slogan NOT FOR GIRLS were easier to interpret by participants as carrying explicit meanings.

1.2.2.2. Affective dimension pattern

This is the second dimension, which is related to how participants felt toward the visual and verbal language used in the selected products. Some participants viewed a product carrying a racial or gender-related message as negative. Many participants cognitively associated a product with a racial or gender-related message and evaluated it as neutral or positive. Also, the neutral products showed that participants did not automatically assign racial/cultural or gender-related meaning to every item.

1.2.2.3. Behavioral dimension pattern

The questions did not explicitly ask participants about buying or rejecting the product even though the acceptance question indicated the behavioral dimension. Some of the answers showed whether participants accepted or rejected a product. One response explicitly stated that she would not eat Yorkie Chocolate even if she were a boy. Another participant described Ras Al Abed as racist but stated she would buy it anyway for its taste. This explains that participants sometimes do not reject a product just because it has negative messages, while at other times they do.

1.2.3. Cross-cultural convergence and divergence

Cross-cultural comparison is important for examining responses between the Lebanese-cultural group and the American-cultural group and identifying similarities and differences in their interpretations. As mentioned before, participants from both cultural groups showed similar recognition when the multimodal elements contained explicit racial or gender-related messages such as Ras Al Abed and Yorkie, while in other cases, participants' prior knowledge of historical and sociocultural background influenced interpretation. This study did not limit participants to certain nationalities but concentrated on their cultural background and upbringing in Lebanese or American culture. A product can be known as Lebanese or American from the visual and verbal language used; for example, a product that has a cedar tree sold in both markets will project a sense of belonging to Lebanese consumers; however, Americans might know this is a Lebanese product, but it will not project the same sense of belonging.

On the other hand, participants from the same cultural group also had differences in their responses, which indicates that sharing the same cultural context may influence participants' responses, but differences can still appear in the same cultural group. These differences might be related to familiarity and prior knowledge. This is not limited to participants from the same culture but also to different cultures, so differences found between the Lebanese-cultural group and the American-cultural group should not be understood as fixed differences between the two cultures but as differences that might be related to familiarity, association, and prior knowledge all together.

Greater similarities appeared when the visual or verbal language in products had explicit elements that guided participants' interpretations which indicate that meaning is constructed through the interaction between the multimodal elements and participants' social knowledge and in return shapes their interpretations. This explains why several products in this study showed similar patterns of interpretations across cultures, while other products received different interpretations within the same cultural groups.

4.2.6 Rebranding and the evolution of product discourse

Language is not fixed; it changes over time. As long as societies are changing, language may change. Rebranding is an example of language change in product discourse that reflects the change in social norms, beliefs, and public knowledge. This process of changing names, slogans, or even images was seen in several products used in this study. Product discourse is prone to change in response to consumers' attitudes toward changes in product discourse. Rebranding also supports the idea that a symbol that was accepted in a certain period might not be accepted later in the same society and may be interpreted as stereotypical, racist, sexist or just inappropriate. Aunt Jemima was rebranded and the company removed the image of the Black lady from their syrup bottles to become Pearl Milling Company in 2021. PepsiCo mentioned that the Aunt Jemima brand carried racial stereotyping messages before the company rebranded (PepsiCo, 2021). Fair and Lovely removed any word that is associated with white, light, or fair and became Glow & Lovely and changed the picture of the brown lady with half face brown and the other half white (Unilever, 2020). Uncle Ben's was also rebranded to Ben's Original and removed the image of the Black man (Mars Food, 2020). This kind of rebranding was not only related to changing the name or the image of a product but rather rebuilding new identities and values.

Other cases involved companies that rebranded their products and apologized for delivering any racial or gender-related issues. NIVEA apologized after launching the ad with the Black man holding a head with an afro hairstyle and removed the commercial altogether, which was the case with H&M that also removed the ad instead of rebranding (Tumposky, 2011; John, 2018). Gandour also renamed Ras Al Abed to Tarboosh (Abou Dib, 2020). The new name carries a more Lebanese identity than Ras Al Abed. Ritika removed any controversial images or ads related to shoes with names associated with religious figures on social media (L'Orient Today Staff, 2025). These examples show that companies might change the name, image, slogan, or sometimes remove the whole advertisement.

Companies may rebrand in response to consumers' criticism of product discourse. This study does not claim that rebranding happens only because of criticism, but the examples show rebranding happens in parallel to changes in social norms and values over time.

1.3. Testing hypotheses

This section of Chapter Four tests the two hypotheses in this thesis using questionnaire classifications, responses to open-ended questions, and patterns across responses.

1.3.1. Testing hypothesis one

H₁: Meaning constructed through the linguistic features within product multimodal elements influences the interpretation of young adults and shapes their response to product discourse, leading to rebranding in most cases.

The interaction between the multimodal elements in product discourse and the rebranding cases both support the first hypothesis. Responses to product discourse that had explicit visual and verbal elements, such as in BIC for Her and Negro Steel Wool, were similar across the two cultural groups. Most participants from both cultures agreed that BIC for Her included gender-related messages, and most participants from both cultures classified Negro Steel Wool as racial/cultural-related. The Yorkie response from US-P15 contains the three dimensions of the Tripartite Model of Attitude where the participants recognized the product and its slogan, effectively interpreted the message as offensive, and showed her rejection of buying the product. This indicates that Hypothesis 1 is supported by the evidence mentioned through the importance of multimodal elements' function in product discourse.

1.3.2. Testing hypothesis two

H₂: The Lebanese sociocultural values, beliefs, and consumers' interpretations are different from those of the United States because of the distinct linguistic choices used in the verbal and visual language of products.

The patterns found across responses supported the hypothesis, but the data showed that divergence also happened in the same cultural group, so the Lebanese-cultural group and the American cultural group cannot be treated as opposites because participants interpreted product discourse in some products the same way while in other products the interpretations varied. Examples like Choco Prince and Mr. Clean were classified as neutral by most participants from the Lebanese Cultural group while they were classified as gender related by most participants from the American Cultural Group. This shows that there are differences in the interpretation of the same product discourse. Another difference can be spotted in the Dark and Lovely interpretations of LB-P30 and US-P18. The Lebanese participant interpreted it as celebrating Black beauty, while the American participant interpreted the message as not accepting natural Black identity. Several Lebanese participants interpreted the message of a Black lady with smooth hair as a message of empowerment while many American participants interpreted it as meaning that the Black lady's natural hair needs to be relaxed to follow Eurocentric standards. This divergence is consistent with sociocultural knowledge. Another example that shows how different sociocultural backgrounds and levels of familiarity may influence interpretations of Ras Al Abed. Lebanese consumers said that familiarity led to normalizing the name, while American participants found the translated name racist as shown in LB-P16 and US-PO9's responses.

1.4. Answering research questions

1.4.1. Answering research question one

1. How do the products' multimodal elements (names, slogans, and images) construct meanings and shape young adult consumers' interpretation across different cultural contexts?

This question is answered through the responses from both cultural groups to products with explicit visual and verbal elements. For example, the slogan "It's not for Girls" with the image of a girl in the prohibition circle or using the word "Negro" in Negro Steel Wool and combining it with a picture of a Black Muscular figure associated with greater convergent responses from both groups. Also, neutral products included visual and verbal elements such as relevant colors, images, and neutral names that communicated the function of the products rather than conveying racial/cultural or gender-related messages. The interaction between the multimodal elements shaped the interpretations across cultures.

1.4.2. Answering research question two

2. How can the verbal and visual language of products affect the three dimensions of attitude of young adult consumers?

Participants answered the open-ended questions that were organized in the questionnaire to match the pattern of the Tripartite Model of Attitude. Participants wrote what message they understood, how they felt towards the language in the provided products, and showed behavior towards product discourse in the acceptability question. Several responses showed that these three dimensions are distinct but related. In this study, the cognitive and affective dimensions were tested more than the behavioral dimension, but many participants included the way they would react in their responses.

1.4.3. Answering research question three

3. What are the similarities and differences in consumers' attitudes toward product discourse in both countries?

This question was answered in detail in the Cross-Cultural Convergence and Divergence section. The study showed similarities and differences in responses from both cultural groups. Similarities were more noticeable when the product included explicit verbal and visual language that conveyed recognizable meanings. However, differences appeared to depend on participants prior knowledge, sociocultural background, and shared values, but these differences existed within the same cultural group. This indicates that shared values, social norms, and cultural background may influence interpretation, but interpretation does not depend solely on these factors.

1.4.4. Answering question four

4. How can sociocultural norms and historical change influence the interpretation of products names, slogans, and images?

As mentioned before, sociocultural norms and historical changes may influence interpretation of product discourse by evaluating whether a name is acceptable or not, or an image is appropriate or not. Participants interpreting Uncle Ben's from the Lebanese cultural group did not recognize the historical context in their interpretations. Other responses of Ras Al Abed and Aunt Jemima also showed that sharing social norms influences interpretations.

1.4.5. Answering question five

5. Do consumers' attitudes affect the product discourse leading to rebranding?

Rebranding of some selected products was not due to participants' interpretations; however, their responses showing recognition, evaluation, and reactions towards the language used in products show patterns that might appear in consumers' responses to product discourse in contexts where rebranding occurred. Consumers' attitudes might be one of the reasons that led to rebranding, but this study cannot prove that consumers' attitudes are the cause of rebranding.

1.5. Chapter summary

Findings from Questionnaire A, Questionnaire B, and the 10 products analyzed by the researcher were discussed in this chapter. The findings indicated that meaning may be constructed through verbal or visual elements, but the interaction between the multimodal elements in a product creates additional meanings. The findings also indicated that shared knowledge, values, and social norms might influence interpretations, but they are not the only factors that shape them. Including neutral products was very important to validate the responses, and it showed that participants did not randomly choose or answer questions.

Chapter 2. Conclusion

2.1. Conclusion

This study examined how young adult participants' attitudes are influenced by product discourse through the Tripartite Model of attitude. It did not test attitude towards the product itself, but towards the verbal and visual language in products found in Lebanese and American markets. It also tested if these interpretations are affected by sociocultural factors, shared knowledge, and time.

The findings in this study showed that some participants interpreted product discourse at multiple levels. Some only interpreted the literal meaning while others dived deeper into the hidden meanings conveyed through the multimodal elements in products. Products that explicitly used verbal and visual language that have racial and gender-related messages were interpreted as such across cultures despite their social backgrounds. Other products that implied meaning through the visual and verbal language needed participants' shared knowledge, sociocultural, and historical background to be able to interpret the message.

This study also showed that meaning is not constructed through the name of products but rather through the interaction between the verbal and visual language. A name might mean one thing, but when it is combined with a slogan or an image, it might mean something different. Also, the use of the Tripartite Model of Attitude organized responses into cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions. This helped to understand participants' responses: first, they understood the language used in products, then they evaluated it by expressing their feelings and indicating whether the product is negative or positive and lastly by acting towards it by accepting or rejecting it.

After that, cross-cultural comparison examined the similarities and differences between the two cultural groups which showed that similarities are found not only between participants from the same group but also between the two cultural groups. Differences are also found not only between the two cultural groups but also within the same cultural group. Findings also showed that familiarity plays a big role in shaping interpretations by normalizing racial or gender-related messages. CDA helped analyze embedded racial- or gender related messages and how meaning is constructed through the multimodal elements. Finally, rebranding showed that product discourse like language is not fixed and changes with social change and therefore is a type of language evolution.

This study is similar to several studies mentioned in Chapter Two. One finding was that gender-related or racial/cultural messages can be communicated to consumers explicitly through the use of names, images, and slogans such as BIC for Her and Yorkie. This is like the study done by Wang (2025) and Zhang (2025), who also examined gender-related advertisements. Another finding in this study was that the verbal language and visual language in products interact to construct meaning and communicate certain messages to consumers. Kayani, Mangrio, and Anwar (2022), Alifah and Hidayat (2024), Attah, Ugwu, and Sa'ad (2025), and Babayeva (2025) also had similar findings. They all showed that ads could construct meaning and communicate messages to consumers using specific linguistic and visual elements. One significant finding was that participants interpreted the same product differently in several cases. This was due to differences in the participants' familiarity with the product and their prior knowledge. Other studies by Petrea, Mihalache, and Costuleanu (2025) showed that commercials are connected to both cultural and intercultural communication, while Hazaea and Qassem (2025) showed that branding discourse affects sociocultural identity. The last finding in this study is related to rebranding. This study showed that like language, product names, images, or slogans can change over time, which was also examined in the studies done by Sangroya et al. (2026) and Ashiq and Carnie (2025). This study concentrated on examining these areas together by evaluating young adult participants' responses from two cultural backgrounds toward the verbal and visual language used in some products sold in the Lebanese and American markets.

2.2. Implications and recommendations

This study is important linguistically because it shows the usefulness of analyzing product discourse through the Tripartite Model of Attitude, multimodal analysis, and cross-cultural analysis to examine how language in products influences interpretations and how consumers' attitudes are shaped towards such products. It also shows that meaning is constructed through social context. An image alone cannot construct meaning on its own; another verbal or visual language must interact to construct meaning. The study also shows that familiarity along with shared knowledge, sociocultural and historical backgrounds influence the understanding, evaluation, and reaction towards product discourse.

This study is important because it shows that companies consider the interaction between the verbal and nonverbal elements in a product. It is important to understand how one element might mean one thing in one culture and mean something else in another, especially if these companies are creating products to be sold in different cultures to avoid misunderstanding of product discourse as sexist or racist. Another indication that makes this study important is that it shows that product discourse like language is prone to change whenever external factors influence rebranding, which is a form of language evolution.

Future researchers might consider including older generations to examine how they would recognize, evaluate, and react towards the same products and examine whether familiarity differs from one generation to another. They can also include direct questions to examine the behavioral dimension more directly, as the affective and cognitive dimensions were more thoroughly examined in this study. Future researchers could also compare interpretations of names before and after rebranding and examine any changes in consumers' attitudes over time.

2.3. Limitations of the study

The first limitation of this study was the age group, which was young adults 18-30 years old so they cannot represent the whole Lebanese or American culture, and this study cannot assume that this is how the older generation would interpret the language in the selected products. Young adults were purposely chosen so the findings apply to this selected group. The second limitation was that this study did not examine every product in the Lebanese and American markets, but only focused on the thirty selected products, so other products might be interpreted differently by consumers. The third limitation was organizing the responses from Lebanese and American cultural groups. Questionnaire A and Questionnaire B were sent to different participants from both groups, which was time consuming to organize the data. Sending two identical questionnaires and sending one as Questionnaire A and Questionnaire A1 to the participants from the Lebanese cultural group and the American cultural group respectively, and the same procedure could have been followed for Questionnaire B, could have made the organization easier and faster. This way, responses in Questionnaire A are purely from the Lebanese cultural group and responses in Questionnaire A1 would only be from the American cultural group. The last limitation was that the study only relied on questionnaire responses from the questionnaires, and adding interviews could have given the participants the opportunity to express how they might react towards product discourse. This explains how they would react but would not show whether they actually buy or reject the product.

2.4. Chapter summary

This study showed that product discourse is not used to sell products faster but can also shape consumers' interpretation and carry social meanings. It also indicated that an image alone will not construct meaning but the interaction between the verbal and visual language can help construct meaning. Another important finding is that interpretations depend on the interaction of social norms, shared knowledge, and sociocultural and historical background with familiarity. Product discourse evolves as long as society evolves.